THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER THREE

“NO CEILING”

March 26 – April 23, 2007
Los Angeles, California

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

COLD OPEN - THE HEADLINES SO FAR

VARIETY - JANUARY 2007

LETERRIER TO SMASH 'HULK'

"Transporter 2" helmer will direct Marvel's fresh start on the green giant, eyed for June 13, 2008 through Universal. Zak Penn writes. Not a sequel to Ang Lee's 2003 film.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "WHO SHOULD PLAY BANNER?" (Page 112 of 112)

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Apr 1, 2007)
Universal wants a movie star. Marvel says "faithful." Banner is a skinny, haunted genius who's scared of himself. Cast an ACTOR, not a brand.

NoNerfsPlz (Apr 1, 2007)
"Nobody gets nerfed" means the Hulk has NO CEILING. The madder he gets, the stronger he gets. If they cap him I riot.

ShellHead1963 (Apr 1, 2007)
Rumor: Marvel is auditioning unknowns. After the Kid Mayor thing I have stopped predicting anything.

FADE IN:

INT. DU-PAR'S RESTAURANT - STUDIO CITY - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, MARCH 26, 2007 - 7:40 A.M. PDT

The same back booth. ELXA BULLOCK (26), baseball cap, no makeup, sits alone with a cold cup of coffee she hasn't touched. Her flip phone sits face up on the table like a ticking bomb. It rings. KEVIN FEIGE. She grabs it.

ELXA
Hi. Hello. Kevin. Hi.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Good morning, Janet van Dyne.

Elxa covers her mouth. Her eyes fill instantly.

FEIGE (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Edgar watched your tape six times. He said you're the first person who made the Wasp funny AND dangerous. We shoot your gala scene April twenty-first, downtown. Nobody knows. Not your brother. Not your mother. Not anybody.

ELXA
(whispering)
Not my mother. Got it.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Especially not your mother.

She hangs up. A WAITRESS (60s) refills her coffee and peers at her.

WAITRESS
You okay, honey?

ELXA
I just got my first job in two years.

WAITRESS
Well, then this coffee's on me.

Elxa laughs through her tears. For once, someone in Los Angeles gave her something for free without knowing her last name.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - CONFERENCE ROOM - BEVERLY HILLS - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 2, 2007 - 10:00 A.M. PDT

The whiteboard has changed. It now reads: "THE INCREDIBLE HULK - BANNER - DECISION BY 4/13." Below it is a column of names, most crossed out. Next to it, Feige has taped a photocopy of the cover of THE INCREDIBLE HULK #1 (May 1962): the original GRAY HULK.

Around the table: FEIGE (33), LOUIS LETERRIER (33), French, wiry, intense, all hand gestures; ZAK PENN (39), screenwriter, rumpled and caffeinated; and LENORA HAYES (42), legal pads aligned.

LETERRIER
In the comic book, it is not an accident in a laboratory. It is a BOMB. A gamma bomb, in the desert. A teenager drives onto the test site and Bruce Banner runs out to save him. He pushes the boy into a trench and the bomb goes off on HIM. He is a hero before he is a monster. This is the whole tragedy, Kevin.

FEIGE
Rick Jones. Incredible Hulk #1, 1962. That's our opening.

PENN
And the first night, he turns GRAY. Like the first issue. Then green. I want fans to scream when they see that gray.

LENORA
I want to remind everyone that Universal is distributing this movie, and Universal has "meaningful consultation" on the lead. Which in English means they get to be loud.

FEIGE
Consultation is not approval.

LENORA
I know that. Universal's lawyers know that. But the man on the phone this morning didn't seem to know that.

PENN
Which man?

LENORA
Gerald Whitfield. Universal's executive VP on the picture. He called me at seven-fifteen to say, and I quote, "Universal expects a recognizable star in the role." He mentioned Edward Norton four times.

LETERRIER
(shrugging, very French)
Edward Norton is a wonderful actor. He is also busy, and expensive, and he will want to rewrite the script.

FEIGE
And he isn't the one I can't stop thinking about.

Feige slides a headshot across the table: AMOND BAKER, smiling, a little goofy, a kids' TV publicity photo from 2001.

PENN
(genuinely surprised)
The funny kid from ALL THAT? The sidekick?

FEIGE
Look past the headshot. Last year Amond Baker shot a dramatic role in a prestige film. They cut his whole part out for running time. I got the deleted scene from a friend at the studio.

He hits play on a laptop. On screen, a 2004 DVD extra: Amond, in a hospital corridor, telling a dying character's daughter that her father is gone. No jokes. No mugging. Just devastation, raw and quiet. The room goes silent.

LETERRIER
(after a long moment)
...Mon Dieu.

FEIGE
That's Bruce Banner. A gentle man who's terrified of the thing inside him. Everyone's been laughing at this kid for ten years. Banner's whole life is people being afraid of what he is. Amond knows exactly what it feels like when nobody sees who you really are.

LENORA
(carefully)
He's also Marc-Anthony Bullock's best friend. If Universal wants a fight, that's the first punch. "Marvel is casting its star's buddies."

FEIGE
Then we do it the same way we did Tayia. He auditions. He earns it in the room, in front of Universal, in front of everyone. If he's not the best, he's not Banner.

LETERRIER
Bring him Friday. And tell him: he will not only read Banner. I want to see him BECOME the Hulk. With his body. If we are doing this with motion capture, the man must be the monster.

CUT TO:

INT. MR. CHOW - BEVERLY HILLS - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, APRIL 3, 2007 - 8:30 P.M. PDT

Black-and-white elegance, celebrities in every booth, waiters in white jackets. In a corner, DESMOND SMILLEY (49), immaculate in a black suit, sits across from GERALD WHITFIELD (58), a silver-haired Universal executive with a tan and a nervous habit of spinning his wedding ring.

GERALD
Desmond, I can push for Norton. I can push hard. But I can't stop Marvel from auditioning whoever they want.

DESMOND
I'm not asking you to stop them. I'm asking you to be in the room. And when the Baker boy finishes, I'm asking you to find something wrong with him. Too funny. Too young. Too connected. Too much a friend of the family. Whatever sticks.

GERALD
(uneasy)
That's a hell of a thing to do to a kid.

Desmond leans in, his voice dropping to velvet.

DESMOND
November 1986. A rainy night on Mulholland. A Porsche in a ditch. A young studio executive who had been drinking. Do you remember who told the police he was driving that car, Gerald?

Gerald stops spinning his ring.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
I lost a cereal commercial over that. My face on the news. I never asked you for anything. For twenty years.

GERALD
(quietly)
...And now you are.

DESMOND
And now I am.

A WAITER sets down a plate of glistening noodles with a flourish. Neither man looks at it.

CUT TO:

INT. AMOND'S APARTMENT - NORTH HOLLYWOOD - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, APRIL 5, 2007 - 10:15 P.M. PDT

The same small apartment, now covered in Hulk comics. THE INCREDIBLE HULK #1. #181. "PLANET HULK" trade paperbacks. Index cards taped to the walls: "BANNER IS NOT SAD. BANNER IS AFRAID." "THE HULK IS NOT ANGRY. THE HULK IS HURT."

AMOND BAKER (25) stands in the middle of the room in sweatpants, shaking out his hands. MARC-ANTHONY (25) sits on the arm of the couch reading lines from a script.

MARC-ANTHONY
(reading as BETTY)
"Bruce. Look at me. You're still in there."

AMOND
(as BANNER, trying)
"I don't... I don't know if I am."

(breaking, frustrated)
Ugh. That was soap opera. That was a guy on the Donohue Channel pretending to be sad.

MARC-ANTHONY
That WAS a guy from the Donohue Channel pretending to be sad. Who cares? So was I. Do it again.

AMOND
Marc, real talk. They're gonna have Edward Norton's agent on speed dial. They're gonna see me walk in and think "Oh, that's the kid who got slimed at the Kids' Choice Awards."

MARC-ANTHONY
You did get slimed at the Kids' Choice Awards.

AMOND
In 1996! I was fourteen! I'm still finding green in my ears!

MARC-ANTHONY
So what's the difference between you and Bruce Banner? He's a guy who got hit with something green and has been trying to wash it off ever since.

Amond stops. He actually laughs.

AMOND
...That's either really deep or really stupid.

MARC-ANTHONY
It's both. That's my whole brand.

(setting down the script, serious now)
Mond. I've known you since we were ten. Do you remember what you did when my grandpa's dog died? When I was twelve?

AMOND
(quietly)
I sat with you on the porch for six hours.

MARC-ANTHONY
You didn't say one joke. Not one. You just sat there and held the leash. Everybody thinks you're the funny one. You're the one who sits on the porch. That's Banner. Bring that guy tomorrow.

Amond's flip phone rings on the counter. MOM. He answers, putting it on speaker.

DENISE BAKER (V.O.)
Baby, I'm not calling to make you nervous.

AMOND
You're calling to make me nervous.

DENISE BAKER (V.O.)
I'm calling to tell you I lit a candle at church and Pastor Greene prayed over your headshot in front of the whole congregation.

AMOND
Mom! It's a closed audition!

DENISE BAKER (V.O.)
God knows it's closed, baby. He's got a key.

Marc-Anthony doubles over laughing. Amond groans, but he's smiling.

CUT TO:

INT. RALEIGH STUDIOS - REHEARSAL HALL B - HOLLYWOOD - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, APRIL 6, 2007 - 11:00 A.M. PDT

The rehearsal hall has been cleared. Black floor, black curtains. A long table: Feige, Leterrier, Penn, casting director SARAH FINN, Lenora, and at the end, arms folded, GERALD WHITFIELD from Universal. A video camera on a tripod. In the corner, a crash mat.

Amond walks in wearing a simple gray T-shirt and jeans. He sees Gerald, who gives him a tight smile.

GERALD
Mr. Baker. Big fan of your... what was it? The sketch show.

AMOND
(politely)
ALL THAT, sir.

GERALD
Right. The slime show.

Feige's jaw tightens slightly. Leterrier doesn't notice; he's already standing, bouncing with energy.

LETERRIER
Amond! Bonjour. Two things today. First, Banner. The scene in the Brazilian bottling plant, alone, after the nightmare. Second, the Hulk. With your body. No words. Okay?

AMOND
Okay.

LETERRIER
Whenever you like.

Amond sits on a folding chair. He closes his eyes. When he opens them, the funny best friend is gone. Bruce Banner sits there, hunched, watching his own hands like they might attack him.

AMOND (AS BANNER)
Two hundred and fourteen days.

(looking at a pulse monitor on his wrist)
Two hundred and fourteen days without an incident. You know what that means? It means I've been awake for two hundred and fourteen days. Because if I fall asleep, if I dream...

(his voice cracks, barely)
...then someone in this city doesn't wake up.

He looks up, directly into the camera. His eyes are wet, but he doesn't cry. Banner never lets himself cry. That would be losing control.

AMOND (AS BANNER) (CONT'D)
They keep asking me what it feels like. To turn into that. And I keep telling them the wrong thing. I tell them it hurts.

(beat, almost a whisper)
It doesn't hurt. That's the problem. It feels like being free.

Silence. Sarah Finn has stopped writing. Penn has his hand over his mouth. Even Gerald has stopped spinning his ring.

LETERRIER
(barely audible)
...Good. Now. The other one.

Amond stands and walks to the center of the black floor. He takes off his shoes. He breathes in. And something starts to happen.

His breathing changes, ragged and deep. His shoulders roll forward. His fingers curl. He drops to one knee, his whole body shaking, a strangled sound coming out of his throat, not acting at fear but fighting something trying to get out. Then he RISES, slowly, impossibly, as if he's suddenly eight feet tall.

He looks down at the table. And it's not Amond looking. It's something old, enormous and wounded.

AMOND (AS HULK)
(a guttural, rumbling growl)
...PUNY... BANNER...

(beat, softer, confused, almost childlike)
...Hulk... just want... be left ALONE.

He SLAMS both fists down onto the crash mat with a THUD that echoes off the walls. Lenora flinches. Then he collapses, and it's Amond again, gasping, on his hands and knees on the floor, soaked in sweat.

Nobody says anything for a full five seconds.

LETERRIER
(rising slowly, a hand to his chest)
Ça, c'est le Hulk.

GERALD
(clearing his throat, too fast)
That was... very physical. I'm just concerned the audience might... laugh. Given his background. A comedian playing the Hulk...

Feige turns to Gerald very slowly.

FEIGE
Gerald. Did you laugh?

Gerald opens his mouth. Closes it.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
Because I looked around this room, and nobody was laughing.

GERALD
(stiffly)
Universal will submit its notes in writing.

FEIGE
We'll read them with great interest.

Amond gets up off the floor, still breathing hard, and looks at the table. He has no idea what just happened.

AMOND
(small, polite)
...Was that okay?

CUT TO:

INT. GERALD'S CAR - UNIVERSAL CITY - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, APRIL 6, 2007 - 3:05 P.M. PDT

Gerald sits in his Mercedes in the Universal parking structure, phone to his ear.

GERALD
He was good, Desmond.

DESMOND (V.O.)
Define good.

GERALD
Leterrier spoke French. The screenwriter cried. I've been doing this for twenty-six years. I've never seen anything like it.

A silence on the line, long and icy.

DESMOND (V.O.)
Then make him bad, Gerald. On paper. You're Universal. Write the memo. Leak the memo. "Universal concerned Marvel is casting cronies." Let the trades do the rest.

GERALD
(closing his eyes)
Desmond...

DESMOND (V.O.)
November 1986, Gerald.

Click. Gerald stares at the phone in his hand for a long time.

CUT TO:

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY - TUESDAY, APRIL 10, 2007, 4:47 PM PT

UNIVERSAL BALKS AT MARVEL'S HULK PICK? "CRONYISM," SAYS SOURCE

A Universal insider tells me that the studio is "deeply concerned" Marvel is about to cast Amond Baker, a former Nickelodeon sketch comic and best friend of IRON MAN star Marc-Anthony Bullock, as Bruce Banner. "It's a buddy system," the source says. "First the co-star gets Pepper, now the best friend gets the Hulk. Who's next, his barber?" Universal wanted Edward Norton. Marvel, I'm told, is not budging...

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - SIMONE'S BEDROOM - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, APRIL 10, 2007 - 9:20 P.M. PDT

Leopard print, a vanity crowded with makeup, a framed photo of a twelve-year-old Simone on her 1990s sitcom set. SIMONE SMILLEY (27) sits cross-legged on her bed, reading the Deadline item on her laptop. ESTHER (24) leans in the doorway.

ESTHER
You wanted to see me?

SIMONE
Close the door.

Esther closes it. Simone turns the laptop toward her.

SIMONE (CONT'D)
Read it.

Esther reads. Her face goes pale.

SIMONE (CONT'D)
Gerald Whitfield had dinner with Daddy at Mr. Chow last Tuesday. I know because my friend Kiki hosts there and texts me every time a Smilley walks in. A week later Universal has "concerns." Same playbook as the Pepper leak. Daddy's not even being creative anymore.

ESTHER
(very quietly)
Why are you telling me?

Simone looks at her little sister for a long beat. Then she smiles, not unkindly.

SIMONE
Because you've been texting "Mayor" under the kitchen table for seven months, baby girl, and you delete every message like you're in the CIA.

Esther's eyes go wide. Busted.

ESTHER
Simone...

SIMONE
I'm not going to tell. I'm not Daddy. I'm the one who got sent to rehab for being "off brand," remember?

(beat, gentler)
That boy is about to get hurt because of us. Again. And his friend is about to lose the only real shot he's ever had. You can sit in the kitchen and pretend you're texting Pastor Williams, or you can do something.

Esther looks down at her pink RAZR. A long moment of decision.

ESTHER
If Daddy finds out...

SIMONE
Daddy can't find out what Daddy can't imagine. And Daddy can't imagine you ever doing anything but smiling.

CUT TO:

TEXT MESSAGE - ESTHER TO "MAYOR"

TUE 4/10/07 9:31 PM

please dont ask how i know this. the deadline thing about amond came from universal. a man named gerald whitfield. somebody is pushing him. tell whoever u need to tell. please be careful

TEXT MESSAGE - "MAYOR" TO ESTHER

TUE 4/10/07 9:33 PM

i wont ask. thank u. i owe u everything. are u ok?

TEXT MESSAGE - ESTHER TO "MAYOR"

TUE 4/10/07 9:34 PM

im ok. tell amond he deserves it. dont tell him i said so lol

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - LENORA'S OFFICE - BEVERLY HILLS - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, APRIL 10, 2007 - 10:05 P.M. PDT

Lenora, glasses on her head, is on speakerphone. Marc-Anthony's voice comes through, uncharacteristically serious.

MARC-ANTHONY (V.O.)
I'm not calling about the casting. I want to be clear. I don't want a vote, I don't want a say, I don't want anything. I'm calling because someone at Universal named Gerald Whitfield is leaking things, and I think someone is paying him to do it.

LENORA
(sitting up, pen ready)
How do you know that?

MARC-ANTHONY (V.O.)
A friend. Someone who took a big risk to tell me. I can't say more.

Lenora writes WHITFIELD on her pad and circles it three times.

LENORA
Marc. If this is true, it's not just dirty. It's a breach of our distribution agreement. A distributor's executive leaking confidential casting information to undermine the producer. That's a lawsuit.

MARC-ANTHONY (V.O.)
I don't want a lawsuit. I just want Amond to get a fair shot. That's all he's ever wanted.

LENORA
(a rare, small smile)
You know what you're doing right now? You're doing exactly what your character does. Finding the loophole that protects the people you love.

MARC-ANTHONY (V.O.)
It's not illegal if nobody wrote it down.

LENORA
Oh, honey. I'm a lawyer. Everybody writes everything down.

CUT TO:

INT. UNIVERSAL STUDIOS - EXECUTIVE TOWER - CONFERENCE ROOM - UNIVERSAL CITY - DAY

SUPER: THURSDAY, APRIL 12, 2007 - 2:00 P.M. PDT

A tense meeting. On one side, Universal's senior legal team. On the other, Lenora, flanked by Marvel's outside counsel and AVI ARAD (58). Gerald Whitfield is conspicuously absent. On a TV in the corner, muted, CNN covers CBS firing radio host Don Imus over his racist remarks about the Rutgers women's basketball team.

Lenora slides a folder across the table: phone logs, email timestamps, the Deadline item, the audition schedule.

LENORA
We're not here to embarrass Universal. We value the partnership. But someone on your side has twice leaked confidential Marvel information with the specific intent of damaging our casting decisions. That person had dinner on April 3 with a talent manager who has a personal grudge against our lead actor's family. We'd like it to stop.

The UNIVERSAL GENERAL COUNSEL (60s) flips through the folder. His expression grows grimmer with every page.

UNIVERSAL GENERAL COUNSEL
...Mr. Whitfield is being reassigned, effective today. Universal has no objection to Marvel's choice for the role.

ARAD
(leaning forward)
May I say something?

Everyone looks at him.

ARAD (CONT'D)
Six months ago, I sat in a room and said Marc-Anthony Bullock was "the boy from KID MAYOR." I was wrong. Last Friday I watched Amond Baker turn into a monster in front of me, and I thought, I'm not going to be wrong twice. Universal doesn't have to love him today. But on June 13, 2008, you're going to be very happy you didn't stand in his way.

CUT TO:

INT. SUDS-N-DUDS LAUNDROMAT - NORTH HOLLYWOOD - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, APRIL 13, 2007 - 6:30 P.M. PDT

Friday the thirteenth. Fluorescent lights hum. Amond sits on a plastic chair watching his clothes tumble, eating a bag of vending machine chips. A TV on the wall plays an old episode of ALL THAT. On screen, fourteen-year-old Amond gets slimed. An OLD MAN (70s) folding towels looks from the TV to Amond and back again.

OLD MAN
Is that you?

AMOND
(sighing)
Yes, sir.

OLD MAN
You got slimed.

AMOND
Yes, sir. 1996.

OLD MAN
Huh. You've gotten taller.

Amond's phone rings. A 310 number he doesn't recognize. He answers, mouth full of chips.

AMOND
Hello?

LETERRIER (V.O.)
Amond! It is Louis. Louis Leterrier. Are you sitting down?

Amond stands up so fast his chips scatter.

AMOND
I'm standing up, actually.

LETERRIER (V.O.)
Then sit down, because you are Bruce Banner. And you are the Hulk. Both of them. The whole thing. With your face, your body, your voice. Universal agrees. Marvel agrees. Everyone agrees. Félicitations, mon ami.

Amond slowly sinks into the plastic chair. He doesn't say anything. He just stares at the TV, where fourteen-year-old Amond is wiping green slime off his face.

LETERRIER (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Amond? Hello?

AMOND
(barely a whisper)
I'm here. I'm here. I just... thank you. Thank you for seeing me.

LETERRIER (V.O.)
You made it very easy, my friend. You made the whole room disappear. Training starts in May. You will be very, very tired.

Click. Amond sits there, the phone against his chest. The old man stops folding towels.

OLD MAN
Good news?

AMOND
(tears streaming, laughing)
I'm gonna be the Hulk.

OLD MAN
(nodding slowly, impressed)
Well. You're already green from the slime.

Amond laughs so hard he has to hold onto the dryer. He dials MOM.

AMOND
Mama? Tell Pastor Greene the key worked.

CUT TO:

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE - BACK PORCH - LOS FELIZ - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, APRIL 13, 2007 - 8:00 P.M. PDT

Amond bursts through the side gate. Marc-Anthony is already running toward him. They collide in a hug so hard they both nearly fall into the pool. GRACE BULLOCK (13, as of yesterday) watches from the doorway, wearing a sparkly "BIRTHDAY GIRL" sash from her party the day before.

GRACE
Is it true? Is it TRUE?

AMOND
Bruce Banner, baby! The Hulk!

Grace screams and runs inside to tell everyone. Marc-Anthony grabs Amond's face with both hands.

MARC-ANTHONY
I didn't do anything. I swear. I didn't call anybody about the part. You got it on your own.

AMOND
I know, man. Louis told me the whole room was crying. He said the Universal guy got moved to "another project."

A flicker crosses Marc-Anthony's face. He knows exactly why. He says nothing.

AMOND (CONT'D)
Hey. What's that look?

MARC-ANTHONY
Nothing. Somebody out there is looking out for you, that's all.

(smiling)
Somebody told me to tell you that you deserve it.

AMOND
Who?

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm not allowed to say. But they're right.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - FEIGE'S OFFICE - BEVERLY HILLS - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 16, 2007 - 9:15 A.M. PDT

Feige, Lenora and Leterrier sit in silence, watching CNN on a small TV. A breaking banner: "SHOOTING AT VIRGINIA TECH." The death toll is climbing. A finished press release sits on the desk, untouched.

LENORA
(quietly)
We were going to send it at noon.

FEIGE
Not today. Not this week. Nobody wants a press release about a giant green monster today.

LETERRIER
He has waited his whole life. He can wait one more week.

Feige turns off the TV. The three of them sit for a moment in the quiet.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT - NEWS WIRE - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 23, 2007 - 6:00 A.M. PDT

MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT, INC. / UNIVERSAL PICTURES - JOINT PRESS RELEASE - APRIL 23, 2007, 6:00 AM PT

AMOND BAKER TO STAR AS BRUCE BANNER IN MARVEL STUDIOS' "THE INCREDIBLE HULK"

Baker Will Also Perform the Hulk Through Full-Body Motion Capture; Film Shoots This Summer on Location in New York City and Rio de Janeiro

LOS ANGELES - Marvel Studios and Universal Pictures today announced that Amond Baker will star as Dr. Bruce Banner in THE INCREDIBLE HULK, directed by Louis Leterrier from a screenplay by Zak Penn, opening June 13, 2008. Baker will play both Banner and the Hulk, performing the character himself through motion capture filmed on location.

In keeping with Marvel Studios' commitment to the source material, the film returns to the character's comic book origin: Banner caught in the blast of a gamma bomb while saving a teenager, Rick Jones. Consistent with the comics, the Hulk's strength has no defined limit.

"Amond's audition was the most powerful thing any of us had ever seen in a room," said Kevin Feige. "We came in looking for an actor who could play a man afraid of himself. We found one who could play the monster too."

"There is no ceiling on the Hulk," said Louis Leterrier. "In the comics, the angrier he gets, the stronger he gets. On screen, we will honor that completely."

"The Hulk was always my Jekyll and Hyde," said Stan Lee. "Amond has the face of Jekyll and the soul of Hyde, in the best possible way. Hulk smash, kiddo!"

MONTAGE - THE INTERNET SMASHES

SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 23, 2007 - THROUGHOUT THE DAY

VARIETY - MON APRIL 23, 2007

BAKER WILL BE GREEN FOR MARVEL

After a reported internal standoff with Universal, the former Nickelodeon player lands the dual role. Sources describe his audition as "seismic." A Universal executive who opposed the casting has been moved off the project.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - MON APRIL 23, 2007

'NO CEILING': MARVEL DOUBLES DOWN ON COMIC FIDELITY WITH HULK ORIGIN, MO-CAP STAR

Gamma-bomb origin and on-location motion capture follow the studio's "Marvel Method." Rival executives call the approach "insanely expensive."

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "OFFICIAL: AMOND BAKER IS BRUCE BANNER / THE HULK" (Page 1 of 88)

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Apr 23, 6:09 AM)
GAMMA BOMB. RICK JONES. NO CEILING. I'm shaking. This is the Hulk I grew up with.

ShellHead1963 (Apr 23, 6:15 AM)
The kid who got slimed at the Kids' Choice Awards is the Hulk. I'm not even going to complain. I've learned my lesson about Marvel's casting.

Repulsor_Ray (Apr 23, 6:21 AM)
ok but the cronyism thing. first his co-star, now his best friend. come on.

WarMachineRox (Apr 23, 6:25 AM)
Read the Variety piece. Universal's own guy got REMOVED for leaking. Leterrier spoke FRENCH in the audition room. Somebody tried to sabotage this dude and failed.

NoNerfsPlz (Apr 23, 6:30 AM)
"THE HULK'S STRENGTH HAS NO DEFINED LIMIT" in an OFFICIAL PRESS RELEASE. Kevin Feige is my president.

GreenSlime96 (Apr 23, 6:44 AM)
i was AT the 1996 kids choice awards when he got slimed. i was 9. now he's the hulk. full circle. i'm 20 and crying in my dorm.

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

gammagal: AMOND BAKER IS THE HULK. the funny one from all that. i love this timeline 6:12 AM Apr 23rd from web

tayiaboyd: my little brother from another mother is the HULK. so proud of you @amondbaker. now go eat 6,000 calories a day 7:40 AM Apr 23rd from web

amondbaker: hi. its me. i just made a twitter. im the hulk now?? thank you mom, thank you god, thank you to the man at the laundromat who said i was already green 9:02 AM Apr 23rd from web

BET - "106 & PARK" - LIVE, MONDAY, APRIL 23, 2007, 6:00 PM ET (ON-AIR SCROLL)

BREAKING: Amond Baker cast as the Incredible Hulk! Two Black superheroes headlining Marvel's first two films. History, y'all!

MYSPACE.COM - AMOND BAKER (OFFICIAL) - BULLETIN

Subject: green with gratitude

for ten years everybody laughed at me. i loved it. i still love it. but today somebody let me cry on camera and keep the take. thank you marvel. thank you louis. thank you to my best friend, who told me to bring the guy who sits on the porch. i brought him.

Comments (9,817) | Kudos (27,340)

CUT TO:

EXT. DONOHUE CONCERT HALL - DOWNTOWN LOS ANGELES - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

SUPER: TWO DAYS EARLIER - SATURDAY, APRIL 21, 2007 - 11:50 P.M. PDT

Frank Gehry's stainless-steel sails glow under film lights, the hall named for Gus Donohue, shimmering like a spaceship. Red carpet. Extras in gowns and tuxedos. A huge banner: "STARK INDUSTRIES - FIREFIGHTERS' FAMILY FUND GALA." Favreau is at the monitors. The scene is Tony arriving at the gala.

Marc-Anthony, in a perfectly tailored tux, takes his mark at the top of the steps. The AD calls "Background, action!" and a woman in a gold and black couture gown sweeps past him on the carpet, a mask of a smile, drink in hand.

WOMAN
(not looking at him, perfectly bored)
Mr. Stark. Your tie is crooked. Your ego, as always, is perfectly straight.

Marc-Anthony turns, ready with Tony's comeback, and FREEZES. The woman is ELXA. His sister. In full JANET VAN DYNE glamour, a tiny gold wasp brooch pinned at her shoulder.

MARC-ANTHONY
(breaking character completely)
ELXA?!

FAVREAU
CUT! Marc, buddy, you can't yell your sister's name at Janet van Dyne!

The crew laughs. Elxa breaks into a huge grin. Marc-Anthony grabs her by the shoulders.

MARC-ANTHONY
What are you... how did you... since WHEN?

ELXA
(whispering, glowing)
I auditioned, like everybody else. Kevin made me sign an NDA in a diner. Nobody knows. Not even Mom.

MARC-ANTHONY
(whispering back)
Especially not Mom.

ELXA
Especially not Mom.

He hugs her right there on the red carpet, in front of two hundred extras.

MARC-ANTHONY
You did it yourself.

ELXA
(her voice cracking)
I did it myself.

FAVREAU
(over the loudspeaker, grinning)
Okay, the Bullock family reunion is beautiful, but this is costing Merrill Lynch eleven thousand dollars a minute. Reset! Janet, please be mean to him again!

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - DESMOND'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 23, 2007 - 10:30 P.M. PDT

The TV plays an ENTERTAINMENT TONIGHT segment: "From Slime to Smash: Amond Baker Is the Hulk!" Desmond mutes it. He's on the phone.

DESMOND
Reassigned. Reassigned to what?

(listening)
Home entertainment. Gerald Whitfield is going to spend the rest of his career approving DVD menus.

He hangs up. Turns slowly in his chair. RUSS KESSLER stands by the bookshelf.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
Marvel knew it was Gerald within four days, Russ. Four days. They had his phone logs. They knew about Mr. Chow.

RUSS
Somebody tipped them off.

DESMOND
Somebody who knew about the dinner. Somebody close.

(beat, very quiet)
Somebody in this house.

A long silence. Down the hall, a door closes softly. Desmond's eyes move to the framed family portrait on his desk: Desmond, Celeste, Julian, Simone, and, at the center, smiling the perfect smile, Esther.

His gaze passes right over Esther and lands on Simone.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
Watch Simone.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - ESTHER'S BEDROOM - SAME TIME

Esther lies in bed in the dark, holding her RAZR to her chest. One new message.

TEXT MESSAGE - "MAYOR" TO ESTHER

MON 4/23/07 10:31 PM

the hulk says thank u. so do i. one day im gonna find a way to thank u properly. in public. with a marching band

She smiles into the dark. Then, like always, she deletes it.

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER THREE